

Policy Terms in Plain Language



Affirmative Action: Rules that the government or an organization (like a university) use to include different kinds of voices. Affirmative action is used to include people of different races, genders, sexualities, disabilities, and more.



Affordability: The ability to pay for a service or thing, deciding if something is too expensive, and how it will be paid for.



Appropriations: Money that is set aside by formal action by Congress for a specific use. Appropriations happen once a year.



Beneficiary: A person who benefits or receives payments or services from a program like Medicaid or Social Security.



Bi-Cameral: When people of both the House of Representatives and Senate work together on a law.



Bi-Partisan: When people of both political parties (Democratic and Republican) work together on a law.



Budget: Money that is requested by formal action by the President's Administration or by Congress for a specific use.



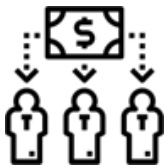
Caucus: A group of people, belonging to the same political party or with similar interests that will make recommendations or make decisions on policy.



Census: A count of how many people live in the country, along with some descriptions of the people. It happens every ten years.



Chamber: The two different parts of Congress – The House of Representatives (The House, for short) and The Senate.



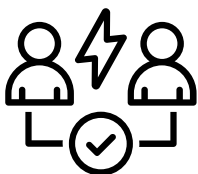
Competitive Integrated Employment: Full or part- time work at minimum wage or higher, with wages and benefits similar to that for people without disabilities doing the same work, and fully integrated with coworkers without disabilities.



Complex: Complicated or difficult to break down and understand.



Constituents: The people who live in the area (called a district, usually one or more zip-codes) or a state that an elected official represents. Example: people in Pennsylvania are Senator Casey and Senator Fetterman's constituents and people in Pennsylvania's first district are Representative Fitzpatrick's constituents. [Click on this link](#) and type in your zip code to find your Representative.



Continuing resolution: This is also called a CR for short. This is something that Congress might pass to extend the federal budget if they cannot agree on a new budget by the deadline. The federal budget ends on September 30th every year, and if Congress cannot agree on a new budget, they will pass a CR to avoid a government shutdown.



COVID-19: Also known as coronavirus or COVID, it is a new virus making people sick all over the world.



Debt Ceiling: The amount of money that Congress is able to spend. The debt ceiling has to be increased every once in a while, to continue to pay for federal programs like special education, Medicaid, Social Security and more.



Direct Support Professionals (DSPs): People whose job it is to provide help to people with disabilities so they can live their best lives. They can provide support for transportation, personal care, housing, home care, community integration and more.



District: The area that you vote in for your Representative in the House of Representatives. The number of people in your state decides how many representatives your state gets.



Eligibility: The requirements that must be met to receive services or benefits from a government program like Medicaid or Social Security.



Ethnicity: A group of people who share their own culture, history, language, religion, or set of traditions



Evidence-based: Making decisions and policy that apply the findings of the best available current research or studies.



Filibuster: The attempt to stop or slow down a vote in the Senate by talking about it for a long time, trying to change the rules, or anything else to delay the vote.



Gender Identity: The way a person feels about themselves and how they choose to express themselves – male, female, both, neither, or other gender.



Home and Community Based Services (HCBS): Supports and services to help people with disabilities live their everyday lives in their communities



Infrastructure: The basic things needed to make something work.



Initiatives: Plans, activities, and strategies that work toward a goal.



Institutions of Higher Learning: Colleges, community colleges, and universities.



Jeopardizing: At risk of losing something like a service or program.



Legislation: Policies, or other matters under consideration by Congress or other parts of government that create or change laws.



Long-term Supports and Services (LTSS): Services that help people with disabilities to live their everyday lives. Some examples of LTSS are job coaches, transportation, and personal care assistants that help you do things in your house.



Markup: This is when a group of Senators or Representatives meet to talk about a bill and make changes to it before voting on it.



Minimum wage: the lowest amount of money that a person can legally be paid for doing a job.



Onset: The beginning of something.



Paid Leave: Time off from work that someone is paid for.



Policy priorities: Issues that our network or other organizations have decided are the most important to work to fix.



Poverty: Not having enough money to live.



Provision: Part of a law or regulation.



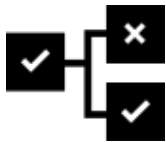
Race: A way we talk about groups of people based on how they look or their family history



Reauthorization: Pass or give money to again, for example approve funding for a program that was already a law.



Recess: When Congress goes on break and the Members travel home to their states and districts to talk to constituents. [Check out this Tuesday's With Liz episode for more information!](#)



Regulation: Instructions from a federal agency on how a law needs to be enforced.



Relief: Lessening the negative effects of an issue or policy sometimes by providing money to people.



Restraint: The action of physically keeping someone in one place.



Restrictive: Putting limits on someone's freedom.



Revenues: The money that a city, county, state, or country government brings in as income, usually as taxes.



Seclusion: The state of being isolated or kept away from others.



Solvency: Having enough money to cover the costs of a program.



Subminimum Wage: Pay for a job that is less money than legally allowed.



Surplus: Extra or left-over funds.



Universal Design: Products or features that are accessible to everyone and benefit everyone.



Vaccine: A shot that keeps us from getting sick.



Work Incentives: Programs from the Social Security Administration that allow people with disabilities to work and receive their monthly payments. The programs can be different in each state or territory.



Association of University Centers On Disabilities